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form of a text message, or as streaming video through your Internet connection. This message can also be relayed to the nearest police control room or security centre.

In addition to this, companies now offer you systems where the doors and windows get locked automatically in case of a break-in, and open up only when a particular security code is entered. This practically traps the thief inside.

Turning Futuristic Into Real

Sound futuristic? Well, it's not just a prediction. Companies around the world are actually providing their customers with such technology. In India, Zicom Electronic Security Systems and Honeywell are providers of high-tech security systems.

With security becoming a buzzword today and with advancements in technology, people are pushing for better and more efficient products to secure their homes. Equipment such as colour CCTVs, digital recording devices, wireless systems, radio frequency identification tags and access control cards, and automated contraband detection devices have an increasing demand.

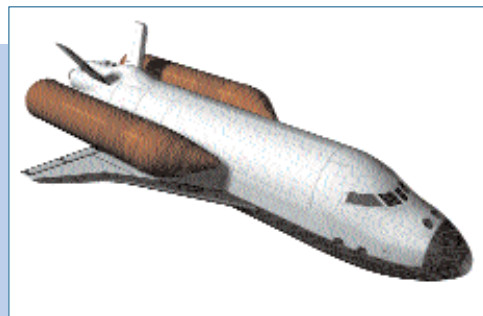
You also have biometric and multiple-PIN security access systems. With multiple-PIN access systems, each house has a secure PIN.

Each member of the household is given another unique access code, too. For entry into the premises, both combinations have to be entered. A failure to do so would trigger an alarm. But are these really high-tech security systems the only effective way to stay protected?

Keeping It Simple

Skylink, a US-based security service provider, has a series of simple security products, such as a little motion detector that you can mount outside the house, and if someone invades your space it signals the base unit to beep and flash. By putting the base unit in the living room and mounting the motion sensor outside the front door, the LEDs (Light Emitting Diodes) on the base unit give you intimation if someone is at your door if you're playing your music or TV so loud that you can't hear the doorbell.

While their basic system configurations require you to be home to see the lights flash and hear the beeps beep, Skylink also offers optional equipment that will send an emergency phone call to your cell phone, pager, or wherever else you want it to yell for help. All this is simple technology packaged elegantly



CCTV cameras can be disguised to look like almost anything. Shown above is a tiny CCTV camera!

that works quite well in today's hi-tech world.

Inix Technology from Malaysia has come up with a simple security system called 'Secure Smith'. Accessible over the Internet, Secure Smith is a wireless product comprising a home security system, electrical equipment automation, home surveillance and CCTV surveillance system.

Secure Smith does not need a PC to run, and neither does it require wiring through your homes or any additional infrastructure. This is because of a proprietary technology that utilises electricity lines to transmit digital data. Each Secure Smith control panel is able to control up to 4,000 home appliances. When the systems are clustered together, they can also be used in office buildings and factories.

Convergence Yet Again

Sophisticated wireless technologies are also being exploited for home automation, which will not only keep our homes secure, but also help us manage the PC and the audio system. By plugging various home devices into Lucent Technologies' HomeStar network, you can set a VCD/DVD player with the same controls used to manage the alarm system.

Before going off on holiday, you can program your audio system to switch on during the evening. This network can control your lighting as well. A passerby would therefore be under the impression that your house is occupied. You can turn your PC with a Web cam into a video surveillance system, too. There also exists software that let you control and manage a video surveillance system and the lighting of your home as well.

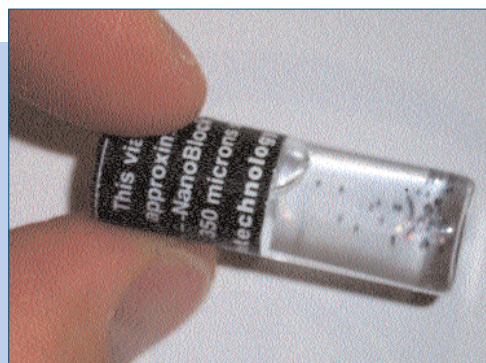
Security For The Masses

Housing complexes across the country are wiring up their homes with the latest security systems. Though many such systems come at a premium (being imported), people aren't cutting expenses on the security front.

Equated monthly payment schemes have made most security features accessible to more people. Residential societies that already have such systems installed just have to add a couple of hundred rupees to the monthly bill for each apartment.

However, a few simple precautions such as securing all windows that could be accessible from the outside, locking your doors, keeping track of your keys, need to be done to secure your homes and your valuables inside. No matter how high-tech a security system you might have in place, there is always a chance that it might fail or be cracked. ■

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RFID sensors as small as this can help in authentication as well as in other areas of home security